FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Restrictive Interventions Policy

Reference: FME-BE-03

Last review: September 2026
Next review: September 2027

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1.0 AIMS AND SCOPE

1.1 Aims

Futures Matter - Northwood is a safe, secure and supportive school for pupils with social, emotional and mental health needs, autism and other complex needs. There are times when the use of restrictive interventions, including reasonable force, restraint and seclusion, is lawful and necessary to keep people safe. We know that using them can have a serious impact on pupils, staff, parents and carers. In our school they are only ever considered as a last resort, once prevention and de-escalation strategies have been tried or are not possible in the moment.

This policy aims to:

- minimise the need for restrictive interventions through early support, prevention and de-escalation
- help staff feel confident to use restrictive interventions safely, appropriately and lawfully when they are necessary
- set out clearly how we record and report every incident of significant force, seclusion and restraint
- protect the safety, wellbeing and dignity of all pupils and staff

1.2 Scope

This policy applies to all staff, including agency staff and volunteers, who work with pupils, and to all pupils at the school. It applies on the school site and when staff are lawfully in charge of pupils elsewhere, for example on a trip or visit. It is a standalone policy, and it should be read with our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy.

Our approach to de-escalation and physical intervention is Global Conflict Management (GCM), delivered by our training provider, JM Training. It is described in Appendix 1 of the Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. Staff only use techniques they have been trained to use.

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

This policy is based on the Department for Education (DfE) guidance, Restrictive interventions, including use of reasonable force, in schools, which came into effect on 1 April 2026. It also meets the requirements of:

- Section 93 of the Education and Inspections Act 2006
- Section 93A of the Education and Inspections Act 2006, inserted by the Apprenticeships, Skills, Children and Learning Act 2009
- Sections 550ZA and 550ZB of the Education Act 1996
- Paragraph 16A of the Schedule to the Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, inserted by the Schools (Recording and Reporting of Seclusion and Restraint) (No. 2) (England) Regulations 2025
- The Equality Act 2010
- The Human Rights Act 1998
- The Health and Safety at Work etc. Act 1974 and associated regulations
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026

- DfE guidance on searching, screening and confiscation

3.0 DEFINITIONS

The terms in this policy are defined as follows. The definitions are based on the DfE guidance listed in section 2.

Term	Meaning
Restrictive intervention	An action used to prevent, restrict or subdue movement of the body or part of the body. We use this as the umbrella term for both physical and non-physical actions that restrain a pupil. Examples are reasonable force, restraint and seclusion.
Reasonable force	The range of actions staff use that involve a degree of physical contact to restrain a pupil, using no more force than is needed, for the least amount of time. What is reasonable depends on the circumstances. Examples are guiding a pupil to safety by the arm, breaking up a fight, and holding a pupil to prevent injury to them or others.
Restraint	A non-disciplinary intervention that immobilises a pupil or limits their movement. It may or may not involve direct physical contact. An example is holding a pupil's arms to their sides when they are trying to harm themselves or others.
Seclusion	A non-disciplinary intervention that keeps a pupil confined to a place away from others and prevents them from leaving, for the safety of the pupil or others. This can be by physical obstruction, or by making the pupil believe they will be punished if they leave. See section 3.2.
Significant incident	Any incident where the use of force goes beyond appropriate physical contact between a member of staff and a pupil. This includes when physical force is used to put a non-physical restrictive intervention in place.
Passive physical contact	For example, a member of staff blocking a pupil's path if they are running towards a busy road, or standing between pupils to stop a fight.

3.1 Appropriate Physical Contact with Pupils

We do not have a 'no contact' policy. We do not agree to requests from parents, carers or staff that reasonable force or other restrictive interventions are never used.

There are times when it is appropriate for staff to have some physical contact with pupils, and this does not raise any question about reasonable force. Examples include:

- giving first aid
- guiding or escorting a pupil through the building or on a trip by holding their hand
- comforting a pupil who is upset, where this is appropriate for the pupil
- offering congratulations or praise, such as a handshake
- demonstrating an exercise or technique in PE or sports coaching

Staff use their professional judgement and consider our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and Staff Code of Conduct. They consider the circumstances, such as whether other adults are present, and factors including the pupil's age, any known vulnerabilities (including SEND and any history of trauma), and whether another approach that does not involve contact would work.

3.2 Seclusion

We do not use seclusion as a planned strategy, and we do not have a room for this purpose. If a pupil needs time away from others to regulate, they are offered a calm space and are free to leave it. Staff stay nearby and keep them in sight where this is safe.

If a pupil is ever prevented from leaving a space, or believes they will be punished if they leave, that is seclusion, even if it was not planned. Seclusion is only ever used as a safety measure when a pupil is highly dysregulated and there is a serious risk of harm. It is never used as a threat or a punishment, and it is not a response to deliberate misbehaviour. During any seclusion:

- the pupil is in a safe place that does not feel threatening or frightening
- the pupil is supervised at all times by at least one member of staff
- the pupil is allowed to leave as soon as the immediate risk of harm has reduced

Any seclusion is recorded and reported as set out in section 12, and the Head Teacher is told on the same day.

4.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Who	Responsibilities
The Proprietor and the School Governance Board	Review and approve this policy. Make sure there is a procedure for recording and reporting every significant incident involving force, seclusion incident and restraint incident, and take all reasonable steps to make sure it is followed. Regularly review and question the data on restrictive interventions. Support and challenge school leaders where practice needs to change, for example where an approach has been used for a long time without effect, or where use is disproportionate for pupils who share a protected characteristic, have SEND or have other vulnerabilities.
The Head Teacher	Is responsible for overall implementation and oversight of this policy. Makes sure staff receive high-quality training on prevention and on the safe and lawful use of restrictive interventions, and that staffing levels support positive behaviour. Monitors incidents and reviews them regularly to improve practice. Makes sure recording and reporting requirements are met. Authorises staff to search a pupil or their belongings. Follows the Complaints Policy for any complaint about restrictive interventions, and follows KCSIE if an allegation is made against a member of staff. Leads on Positive Behaviour Support Plans and risk assessments for pupils with SEND, working with parents, carers, staff and other professionals, and advises on reasonable adjustments.

Who	Responsibilities
The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) and Deputy DSLs	Report every seclusion, restraint and significant incident to each parent or carer of the pupil involved. Make sure records are kept securely and in line with safeguarding and data protection procedures. Contact the local authority where telling a pupil's parent or carer would put the pupil at risk of significant harm (see sections 12.2 and 12.4). When the Head Teacher or DSL was directly involved in an incident, a Deputy DSL or the Proprietor reviews the record and the report to parents.
All staff	Read and understand this policy and the policies linked to it. Use de-escalation and positive behaviour strategies to prevent the need for restrictive interventions. Record every seclusion, restraint and significant incident they are involved in, accurately and on the same day where possible, and report it to the DSL. Record any injuries and follow the Health and Safety Policy, including reporting to the Health and Safety Executive where needed. Take part in training for their role. Take part in the debrief and reflection that follows an incident.
Staff who know the pupil best	Help identify and manage risk, such as the triggers and times when challenging behaviour is more likely. Help to develop and review Positive Behaviour Support Plans and prevention and de-escalation strategies for each pupil.

5.0 ACCEPTABLE USES OF FORCE

All our staff have a legal power to use reasonable force in certain situations. Staff can use reasonable force to prevent or stop a pupil from:

- hurting themselves or others
- committing a criminal offence
- damaging property
- causing disorder among pupils, in or out of lessons

All staff have this power, but some staff, especially those who work closely with pupils who may show challenging behaviour, are more likely to need it. We make sure staff are suitably trained and that risk assessments are carried out where needed (see section 11). Every significant incident involving force is recorded and reported as set out in section 12.

6.0 UNACCEPTABLE USES OF FORCE

It is illegal to use force on a pupil as a punishment. We never use force as a sanction, a threat or a deterrent. Any form of force or restraint carries a risk of physical and psychological harm, so we avoid it where we can.

The following are never acceptable:

- using force as a punishment

- restraining a pupil in a way that affects their airway, breathing or circulation, for example by covering their nose or mouth, or by applying pressure to their neck or abdomen
- using force on the ground (if a pupil is unintentionally held on the ground, staff release their hold or move to a safer position as quickly as possible)

Section 5 sets out when staff may use reasonable force. Section 9 sets out what staff must consider before using it.

7.0 USING REASONABLE FORCE TO SEARCH PUPILS

The Head Teacher, and any member of staff the Head Teacher authorises, has a statutory power to search a pupil or their belongings if there are reasonable grounds to suspect the pupil has a prohibited item (as listed in the DfE searching, screening and confiscation guidance) or an item banned under our school rules.

Staff can use reasonable force to search for prohibited items, such as knives, weapons, stolen items or illegal drugs. They cannot use reasonable force to search for items that are banned under our school rules only, such as items linked to gambling.

The decision to use reasonable force to carry out a search is made carefully, case by case, taking into account the risk to pupils and staff and the pupil's history, including any trauma. Our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy (section 11) explains how we search, and the search record form is in Appendix 2 of that policy.

8.0 PREVENTION AND DE-ESCALATION STRATEGIES

Restrictive interventions are only used when necessary. We aim to use them as little as possible, through both whole-school and individual approaches.

8.1 Whole-School Approach

- a calm, predictable and well-organised school and classroom environment that helps every pupil to feel safe
- consistent routines and expectations, set out in the Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- a trauma-informed and attachment-aware approach, building trusting relationships between pupils and key adults
- training staff in effective communication, including tone of voice, body language and empathy
- supporting staff to stay regulated themselves, through reflective supervision and debriefs (Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy, section 2.4)
- recording and analysing data on restrictive interventions to inform improvement planning

8.2 Individual Approaches

- working closely with parents and carers to support each pupil
- Positive Behaviour Support Plans based on each pupil's identified needs, triggers and what helps them to calm
- strategies to help a pupil calm down before their behaviour escalates

- reasonable adjustments where a pupil has a disability, so they can take part in school life as fully as possible
- advice from clinicians and other professionals where needed

8.3 De-escalation when a Situation Arises

When a situation arises where a restrictive intervention may be needed, staff try to de-escalate first wherever possible. In line with our GCM training, this may include:

- open body language, and awareness of the pupil's personal space
- taking the pupil away from an audience, and speaking to them quietly and on their own
- using empathy, and asking the pupil to help us understand how they feel
- distraction, and offering choices
- offering a calm space where the pupil can regulate themselves
- calling a colleague to help or to take over

9.0 WHEN TO USE A RESTRICTIVE INTERVENTION

9.1 Necessity and Proportionality

The decision to use a restrictive intervention is down to the professional judgement of the member of staff and always depends on the circumstances. Staff always consider whether there is another way to manage the situation, such as de-escalation or help from a colleague. Sometimes there is no other choice, and a restrictive intervention is needed to reduce the risk of harm to the pupil or others.

Staff always ask:

- **Is it necessary?** Are there other, more effective and less restrictive ways to manage the situation? Is a restrictive intervention likely to reduce the risk, or could it escalate the situation or cause more harm than the behaviour itself?
- **Is it proportionate?** Use the least force or the least restrictive intervention, for the least amount of time, needed to reduce the risk. If the intervention is making things worse, reconsider and try another approach. Consider the pupil's age, size, medical conditions, SEND and other vulnerabilities.

9.2 Pupil and Staff Welfare

The most important consideration is the safety and wellbeing of the pupil involved, and the safety of other pupils and staff. Staff consider the possible impact on the pupil. Pupils who have experienced trauma or neglect, or who have medical conditions, sensory impairments, communication difficulties or other needs, may find a restrictive intervention especially distressing.

Staff always try to protect the pupil's dignity, including thinking about where the intervention takes place and who can see it. Wherever possible, staff tell the pupil calmly what is happening, why, and what they need to do, using verbal and non-verbal approaches and giving the pupil time to process and respond. Staff watch how the pupil is feeling, and use this to decide whether the intervention should continue, be reduced or stop.

9.3 Support After an Incident

As soon as possible after any restrictive intervention, we look at what happened and why, the effect on pupils and staff, any patterns, and how another incident could be avoided. We make sure each pupil and member of staff involved gets the right support, including medical assessment and treatment if needed, and a chance to reflect on and talk through the incident.

The debrief is based on separate reflections from everyone involved, and aims to repair and rebuild relationships. Where possible, it is led by a member of staff who was not involved in the incident, and an additional person can be present to support impartiality. Support may also be offered to anyone who saw the incident. We keep checking the wellbeing of the pupil and staff afterwards. Appendix 2 can be used to record the debrief.

10.0 PUPILS WITH SEND AND OTHER VULNERABILITIES

Pupils with SEND may react to distressing or confusing situations in ways that can harm themselves or others. Pupils who find it hard to communicate in words may show their needs and discomfort through their behaviour. We are committed to understanding what may trigger challenging behaviour and to providing the right support and an inclusive environment.

We carry out risk assessments for pupils where there is an increased likelihood that reasonable force or another restrictive intervention may be needed. We know our duty under the Equality Act 2010 to make reasonable adjustments for pupils with disabilities. We use staff who know pupils well to help identify triggers and develop proactive strategies, and we work with the pupil, their parents or carers and other professionals. Strategies may include:

- removing things that are causing distress
- changing how staff communicate, for example body language, facial expression and tone of voice
- helping the pupil to express emotions before they become overwhelmed
- engaging the pupil in activities that help them to regulate
- redirecting attention with familiar objects or activities

Where appropriate, we create an individual Positive Behaviour Support Plan. It is reviewed regularly, and after any significant incident, with the pupil and their parents or carers. The plan:

- sets out any adjustments, for example to parts of the school environment the pupil finds hard
- explains the best ways to communicate with the pupil
- in some cases, says when more physical contact with staff may be appropriate. This is discussed with everyone involved and written down in the plan

Recording a restrictive intervention in a pupil's plan does not remove the need to record and report each incident that happens.

11.0 TRAINING AND RISK ASSESSMENTS

All staff who are likely to need to use reasonable force or other restrictive interventions are trained in their safe and lawful use, and in prevention, through accredited GCM training. We

keep a record of who has been trained and when, and refresher training is arranged in line with the provider's guidance. Staff only use the techniques they have been trained to use. A member of staff who has not been trained can still use reasonable force where there is no safe alternative, for example to protect a pupil from immediate danger, and they report it in the same way.

We also have a duty to protect the health, safety and welfare of our staff. We carry out risk assessments so that staff who regularly work with pupils who may need restrictive interventions can do so as safely as possible. Training and risk assessments are reviewed after any significant incident and whenever a pupil's needs change.

12.0 RECORDING AND REPORTING ARRANGEMENTS

We have a legal duty to record and report every:

- significant incident involving force (see section 3 for the definition)
- seclusion incident
- restraint incident

12.1 Recording Incidents

Staff record every incident listed above on CPOMS, under the category set up for restrictive interventions. If CPOMS is not available, they complete the form in Appendix 1 and add it to CPOMS as soon as it is available. Staff record the incident in writing as soon as possible after it happens, and aim to do this on the same day. They do this even where the use of restrictive interventions is agreed in the pupil's plan.

For a significant incident involving force, we record:

- the names of the pupil and the staff directly involved
- any relevant needs or circumstances of the pupil, including any identified special educational need or disability and their SEN status code
- the time, date, location and approximate length of the intervention
- a clear and brief description of what happened, including what led up to it, any known or likely triggers, any prevention or de-escalation used, the type and degree of force used, and any physical injuries
- a brief explanation of why using force was necessary in that situation
- details of any support given afterwards, such as medical help or emotional support

For a seclusion incident or a restraint incident, we record:

- the names of the pupil and the staff directly involved
- any relevant needs or circumstances of the pupil, including any identified special educational need or disability and their SEN status code
- the time, date, location and approximate length of the intervention
- a brief explanation of why the intervention was necessary in that situation
- details of any physical injuries
- details of any support given afterwards, such as medical help or emotional support

We also record the pupil's and any witnesses' accounts where they are available, when and how parents or carers were told, and any follow-up action. If a seclusion or restraint incident

is also a significant incident involving force, it is recorded once, in line with the process for significant incidents. Records are kept securely and kept in line with our data protection procedures.

12.2 Reporting Incidents to Parents and Carers

The member of staff completes the record on CPOMS and tells the DSL or a Deputy DSL. The DSL or a Deputy DSL checks the record and contacts each parent or carer, by telephone where possible, and then confirms the details in writing. The Head Teacher is told of every incident on the same day. We tell parents and carers as soon as we can, and aim to do so on the same day. We do this even where the use of restrictive interventions is agreed in the pupil's plan.

There is one exception. If a member of staff thinks that telling a pupil's parent or carer would be likely to result in significant harm to the pupil, we report the incident to any parent or carer who can be told without that risk. If there is no one, we report it to the local authority where the pupil usually lives (see section 12.4).

When we report a significant incident involving force, we give:

- the time, date, location and approximate length of the intervention
- a brief explanation of why the intervention was necessary in that situation
- a short description of the type and degree of force used
- details of any physical injuries

When we report a seclusion incident or a restraint incident, we give parents and carers written information about the incident, including the details recorded under section 12.1. We follow data protection requirements when deciding what to share, and we do not include identifying details of any other pupil. We also tell the placing local authority of significant incidents where this is part of the pupil's placement arrangements.

12.3 Following Up with Parents and Carers

Where appropriate, we invite parents and carers to a follow-up discussion about the incident. This may cover:

- any triggers or warning signs of an incident
- whether the pupil's Positive Behaviour Support Plan was followed
- which de-escalation strategies were used and how well they worked
- what could be done differently in future

12.4 Reporting Incidents to the Local Authority

Where we decide an incident must be reported to the local authority where the pupil usually lives, the report includes everything we would normally share with parents or carers, and the reasons we thought it was unsafe to tell them directly.

If a pupil has parents or carers and is subject to a care order under section 31 of the Children Act 1989, or is accommodated under section 20 of that Act, we report the incident to the relevant local authority as well as to the parents or carers, unless we decide it is unsafe to tell the parents or carers. For a looked-after child we also tell the social worker and the Virtual School Head.

13.0 COMPLAINTS AND ALLEGATIONS

Complaints about the use of restrictive interventions are handled under our Complaints Policy, which is on our website and available from the school office.

We take any allegation of inappropriate use of force or other restrictive intervention against a member of staff very seriously. We deal with allegations in line with KCSIE and our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy. Allegations about a member of staff go to the Head Teacher. Allegations about the Head Teacher go to the Proprietor, as case manager. The Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO) is contacted where required.

14.0 MONITORING ARRANGEMENTS

The Head Teacher reviews every restrictive intervention record and looks at patterns each term, including by pupil, staff member, time and place, SEND status and protected characteristics, to see whether practice needs to change. The School Governance Board receives an anonymised summary each term, and the Board and Proprietor use it to challenge and support the school.

This policy is reviewed every year by the Head Teacher, and is approved by the Proprietor and the School Governance Board. It is also reviewed when the law or DfE guidance changes, and after any serious incident.

15.0 LEGISLATION, GUIDANCE AND REFERENCES

- Restrictive interventions, including use of reasonable force, in schools, DfE, effective 1 April 2026
- The Education and Inspections Act 2006, sections 93 and 93A
- The Education Act 1996, sections 550ZA and 550ZB
- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, paragraph 16A of the Schedule
- The Schools (Recording and Reporting of Seclusion and Restraint) (No. 2) (England) Regulations 2025
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026
- Searching, screening and confiscation, DfE
- The Equality Act 2010
- The Human Rights Act 1998
- Model policy: use of restrictive interventions, The Key, March 2026

16.0 RELATED POLICIES

- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Complaints Policy
- Health and Safety Policy
- Special Educational Needs Policy
- Anti-Bullying Policy
- Staff Code of Conduct

17.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Incident Record

Appendix 2: Debrief Record

APPENDIX 1: INCIDENT RECORD

Record every significant incident involving force, seclusion incident and restraint incident on CPOMS. Use this form only if CPOMS is not available, and add it to CPOMS as soon as it is.

INCIDENT RECORD - to be completed by the member of staff	
Type of incident (significant incident involving force, restraint or seclusion):	
Pupil's name, and any SEND, EHC plan or other relevant needs (including SEN status code):	
Staff directly involved:	
Date, time, location and approximate length of the intervention:	
What led up to the incident, and any known triggers:	
Prevention and de-escalation used before the intervention:	
What happened, including the type and degree of force used:	
Why the intervention was necessary:	
Any injuries to the pupil or staff, and first aid or medical help given:	
Support given to the pupil and staff afterwards:	
Witnesses, and the pupil's own account (if available):	
Parent or carer told (by whom, how, date and time), or reason they were not told:	
Head Teacher and DSL told (date and time):	
Signed and dated:	

APPENDIX 2: DEBRIEF RECORD

Use this record for the debrief after an incident. It is kept with the CPOMS entry.

DEBRIEF RECORD - to be completed by the person leading the debrief	
Date of incident, pupil and staff involved:	
Who led the debrief, and who took part:	
Pupil's view of what happened, and how they felt:	
Staff views of what happened, and how they felt:	
Triggers or warning signs identified:	
Prevention and de-escalation strategies used, and how well they worked:	
Whether the Positive Behaviour Support Plan and risk assessment were followed:	
What could be done differently in future:	
Changes needed to the pupil's plan or risk assessment:	
Support offered to the pupil, staff and anyone who saw the incident:	
Follow-up with parents or carers (date and outcome):	
Signed and dated:	